

The Interpreter

She translated words for a living. But some things she heard were not meant to be translated.

CEFR Level A2

Book 5 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A conference centre in Brussels. An international pharmaceutical conference.

Genre: Drama / Moral Dilemma

Characters

- Marta — 36. Conference interpreter. Spanish-English-French. Precise and professional.
- Dr. Solis — 55. A pharmaceutical executive. Spanish. The speaker she is interpreting.
- Helene — 42. Marta's colleague. More experienced, more pragmatic.
- The journalist — a stranger Marta meets in the hotel bar.

The interpreters' booth was a small glass room at the back of the conference hall.

Marta had worked in booths like this for twelve years. She knew the particular silence of them — separated from the room by glass, connected to it by sound. She put on her headset, checked the channel, and looked out at the audience.

Three hundred delegates. An international pharmaceutical conference. Two days.

Dr. Solis was about to begin his presentation. Marta had read his notes the night before.

She was ready.

Dr. Solis spoke in Spanish. He was polished — too polished, Marta thought. He spoke the way people speak when they have rehearsed every sentence.

She translated automatically, without thinking, the way she always did in the first twenty minutes.

His presentation was about a new drug — a treatment for a common heart condition.

The data he presented showed excellent results.

Ninety-three percent efficacy.

The delegates were impressed. She could tell from the stillness in the room.

At the first break, Marta and Helene swapped booths, as they always did.

They had fifteen minutes. They went to the small room behind the hall for coffee.

'He's good,' Helene said, meaning Dr. Solis. 'Very clean delivery.'

'Very prepared,' Marta said.

'Is there a difference?' Helene said.

Marta didn't answer. She was thinking about a phrase Dr. Solis had used — a phrase that had come out slightly differently from his notes.

She had translated it as he said it. But she had kept it in her mind.

In the second session, Dr. Solis moved to the side effects section.

He listed the side effects smoothly, professionally.

And then he said, in Spanish, almost under his breath — almost, but not quite:

'We'll leave out the cardiac incidents for now.'

Marta translated everything he said out loud. But she did not translate that sentence.

She paused for less than a second. She continued.

In her headset, she heard Helene's voice from the other channel: 'Did he just—' 'Yes,' Marta said. 'I heard it.'

Interpreters had a strict protocol. You translated what was said. You did not add. You did not remove.

You were a channel — not a participant.

Marta had followed this rule for twelve years without exception.

But the sentence Dr. Solis had spoken under his breath — it had been spoken aloud. Into a live microphone. By someone who perhaps didn't realise the microphone was still on.

Or perhaps he had. Marta didn't know.

She focused on his words and kept translating.

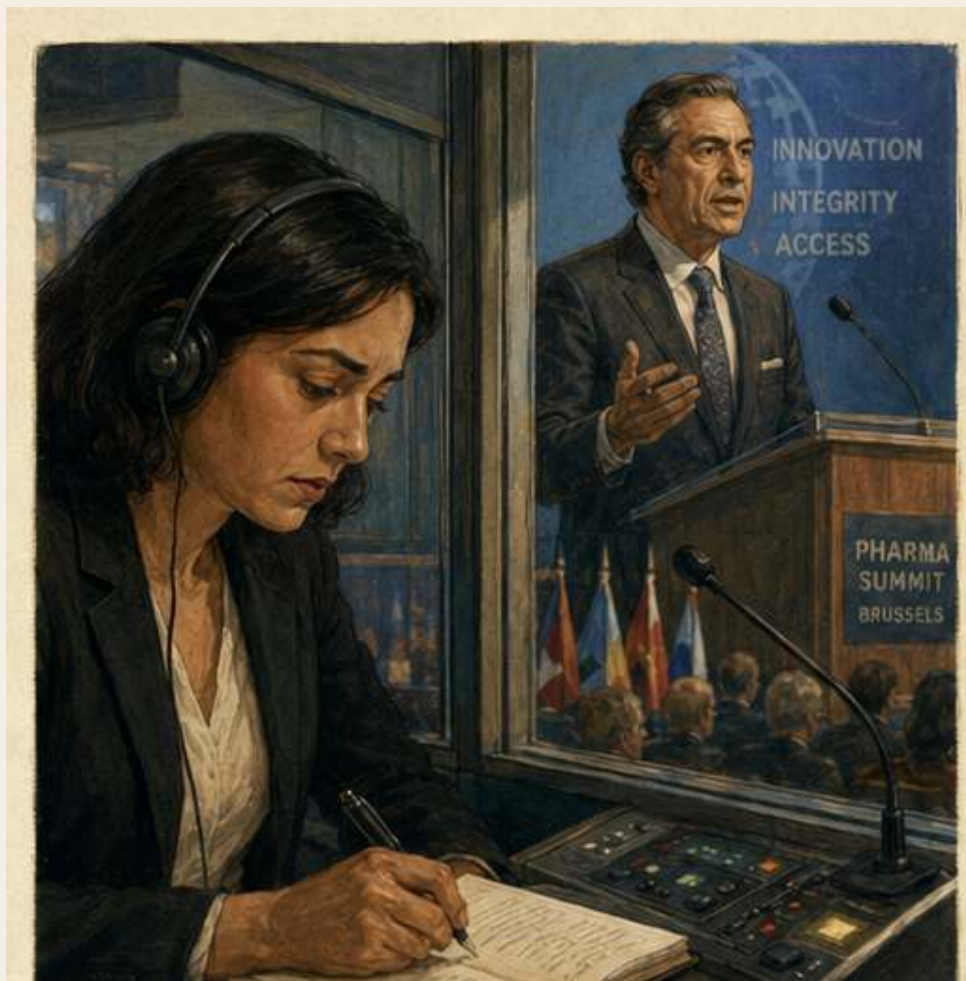
After the afternoon session ended, Marta sat in the booth alone.

Helene came in and closed the door.

'We need to talk about what happened,' Helene said.

'He said it into the microphone,' Marta said. 'I heard it clearly.'

The Interpreter



Marta begins interpreting at an international pharmaceutical conference.

'But you didn't translate it.' 'No.' 'Because you didn't know what it meant?' 'No. I know exactly what it means. Cardiac incidents are adverse cardiac events. Possibly serious ones.'

Helene sat down. 'We're interpreters. We're not regulators. We're not journalists.'

'I know,' Marta said.

That evening, Marta went through the conference materials again in her hotel room.

She compared Dr. Solis's prepared notes with what he had actually said.

The notes mentioned cardiac monitoring as a precautionary measure.

What he had said was: we'll leave out the cardiac incidents.

These were not the same thing.

She wrote down the exact words in her notebook, with a time stamp from the session recording.

Then she sat on the bed and thought for a long time.

She went down to the hotel bar at nine o'clock.

A man at the next table was typing on a laptop. He had a press badge on his jacket.

She ordered wine. She did not speak to him.

But after twenty minutes he looked up and said, 'Interpreter?' He had noticed her conference badge.

'Yes,' she said.

'Interesting work,' he said. 'Hearing everything. Being heard by no one.'

Marta looked at him. 'Usually that's fine,' she said.

'And tonight?' he said.

Marta didn't answer. She drank her wine.

She did not tell the journalist. She went to bed at eleven.

She did not sleep well. She thought about the protocol. She thought about the delegates in the room — doctors, researchers, hospital buyers.

She thought about the patients who would eventually take the drug.

In the morning, she made a decision.

She was not going to speak to the journalist.

She was going to speak to the conference organiser.

The conference organiser was a Belgian woman named Sophie.

Marta found her before the morning session.

'I need to report something,' Marta said. 'About yesterday's presentation.'

She showed Sophie the notes — the prepared version versus what had actually been said. She showed her the exact quote and the timestamp.

Sophie read it carefully. Her face did not change.

'I'll need to listen to the session recording,' Sophie said.

'I'll need to do this formally.'

'I know,' Marta said. 'That's why I came to you.'

Helene was not happy.

'You understand what this will do to our reputation?' she said, when Marta told her.

'I translated exactly what he said out loud,' Marta said.

'I didn't add anything. I didn't remove anything. Except that one sentence — which he spoke into a live microphone and appeared not to intend.'

'Appeared not to intend,' Helene repeated. 'You don't know that.'

'No,' Marta agreed. 'That's why I reported it and let them investigate, rather than deciding myself.'

Helene looked at her for a long moment. Then she nodded — once, slowly.

The Interpreter



Marta starts to suspect that something important is wrong.

The conference paused Dr. Solis's afternoon session. An official from the regulatory body that co-sponsored the conference was called in.

Marta gave a formal statement. She read her notes aloud.

Dr. Solis was asked to explain the discrepancy between his prepared remarks and what he had said.

Marta did not hear the outcome directly — she was asked to wait outside.

After forty minutes, Sophie came to find her.

'The session has been suspended,' Sophie said. 'Pending a full review of the trial data.'

Two months later, Marta read a news article about the case.

The drug trial had been paused. An independent review had found that the cardiac incident data had been incompletely reported in several earlier studies.

Dr. Solis's company was under investigation.

No one mentioned the interpreter.

Marta read the article at her kitchen table. She put down her coffee. She looked out the window.

She thought: I did the right thing. And she thought: I will probably never know how right.

Then she got up and went to work.

Helene called her on a Friday evening.

'I read the article,' Helene said.

'So did I,' Marta said.

There was a pause. Then Helene said: 'I owe you an apology. I was more worried about our reputation than about what was right.'

'You raised a valid concern,' Marta said.

'I was wrong,' Helene said simply. 'You were right.'

Marta was quiet for a moment. 'We're both going to keep getting these jobs,' she said. 'So let's just move on.'

Helene laughed — surprised and slightly relieved.

The following spring, Marta was asked to give a short talk at an interpreters' training day.

The topic was professional ethics.

She talked about the case — without naming anyone — as an example of a moment where protocol and ethics had met.

'The protocol says: translate what is said,' she told the group. 'And I did. I translated everything he said out loud.'

'But what he said under his breath — that was also out loud. Into a microphone. In a room full of people who had a right to that information.'

A young interpreter in the front row raised her hand.

'What if you'd been wrong?' the young interpreter asked. 'What if it had been an innocent mistake?'

Marta had thought about this.

'Then the investigation would have shown that,' she said. 'My job was not to decide what the sentence meant. My job was to report what I heard and let people with the right authority decide.'

'But you didn't translate it into the room,' the young interpreter said.

'No. Because it was spoken below the level of a full statement — quietly, between takes. I used my judgement. I might have been wrong about that.'

She paused. 'Judgement is not perfect. But it's what we have.'

After the talk, Marta drove home.

She had two conferences the following week. One in Geneva, one in Madrid.

The Interpreter



Professional accuracy turns into a difficult moral decision.

She thought about the work — the strange intimacy of it. You sat behind glass and you heard everything. You were present in rooms where decisions were made, agreements were signed, secrets were almost kept. And you translated. You carried the words from one language to another.

Most of the time, this was unremarkable.

Once in twelve years, it had been something else.

In Madrid, Marta was interpreting at a climate policy conference.

The speaker was a government minister. He spoke quickly and precisely.

Marta followed him without difficulty.

Halfway through the session, the minister paused, looked at his notes, and said quietly — barely audible — 'Is this microphone still on?'

It was. Marta translated his question.

There was a brief laugh from the audience. The minister smiled.

Marta smiled too, in the booth. That was the easy kind.

On the second day in Madrid, Marta sat in the booth at eight fifty, waiting for the session to begin.

She looked out through the glass at the delegates — two hundred people talking, checking phones, drinking coffee.

She thought: all of this depends on accuracy. On getting the words right.

She thought about the pharmaceutical conference.

About the sentence that had been almost-hidden.

She put on her headset.

'Ready?' her colleague asked through the intercom.

'Ready,' she said.

Marta had a theory about language.

She believed that people said more than they intended — and also less.

What was said out loud was only part of the communication. What was meant, what was avoided, what was almost said — that was the rest.

Her job was the out-loud part. The translated, transmitted, receivable part.

But she was also a person. And people heard more than just words.

She had done the right thing. She still believed that. The speaker began. Marta began.

Words flowed from one language to another, through glass, across a room, in both directions at once.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. booth	tercüman kabini
2. headset	kulaklık
3. delegates	delegeler
4. pharmaceutical	ilaç sektörüne ait
5. channel	kanal
6. separated from	... den ayrılmış
7. rehearsed	prova yapmış
8. automatically	otomatik olarak
9. efficacy	etkinlik
10. heart condition	kalp hastalığı
11. stillness	sessizlik
12. treatment	tedavi
13. swapped	değiştirdiler
14. delivery	sunum tarzı
15. phrase	ifade, söz öbeği
16. slightly differently	biraz farklı
17. kept it in her mind	aklında tuttu
18. side effects	yan etkiler
19. under his breath	kendi kendine fısıldayarak
20. cardiac incidents	kalp olayları, komplikasyonlar
21. smoothly	akıcı şekilde
22. leave out	çıkarmak, atlamak
23. protocol	protokol
24. participant	katılımcı
25. exception	istisna
26. live microphone	açık mikrofon
27. focused on	odaklandı
28. strict	katı
29. regulators	düzenleyici kurumlar
30. adverse events	olumsuz olaylar
31. clearly	açıkça
32. journalists	gazeteciler
33. serious	ciddi
34. compared	karşılaştırdı
35. precautionary measure	önleyici tedbir
36. monitoring	izleme
37. time stamp	zaman damgası
38. exact words	tam ifadeler

39. session recording
40. press badge
41. conference badge
42. heard by no one
43. usually
44. typing
45. eventually
46. organiser
47. buyers
48. researchers
49. made a decision
50. report something
51. versus
52. quote
53. formally
54. reputation
55. investigate
56. appeared not to intend
57. agreed
58. slowly
59. regulatory body
60. statement
61. discrepancy
62. suspended
63. pending
64. trial data
65. incompletely reported
66. independent review
67. under investigation
68. mentioned
69. got up
70. owe an apology
71. valid concern
72. move on
73. relieved
74. simply
75. professional ethics
76. protocol

- oturum kaydı
basın kartı
konferans kartı
kimse tarafından duyulmaz
genellikle
yazıyor
eninde sonunda
organizatör
alıcılar
araştırmacılar
karar verdi
bir şeyi bildirmek
karşı, karşısında
alıntı
resmi olarak
itibar
soruşturmak
niyet etmemiş gibi göründü
katıldı
yavaşça
düzenleyici kurum
ifade, beyan
tutarsızlık
askıya alındı
bekleyen
deneme verileri
eksik raporlanmış
bağımsız inceleme
soruşturma altında
söz etti
kalktı
özür borçluyum
geçerli endişe
devam etmek
rahatlamış
sade bir şekilde
mesleki etik
protokol

77. naming anyone	isim vermek
78. right to information	bilgi hakkı
79. front row	ön sıra
80. innocent mistake	masum hata
81. right authority	doğru yetkili
82. judgement	yargı, karar
83. between takes	alımlar arasında
84. perfect	mükemmel
85. intimacy	yakınlık
86. agreements	anlaşmalar
87. unremarkable	sıradan, dikkat çekmez
88. carry	taşımak
89. present in rooms	odalarda mevcut
90. climate policy	iklim politikası
91. audible	işitilebilir
92. precisely	kesin olarak
93. brief laugh	kısa gülüşme
94. halfway through	yarısında
95. accuracy	doğruluk
96. intercom	dahili iletişim sistemi
97. depends on	... e bağlı
98. almost-hidden	neredeyse saklanmış
99. getting the words right	kelimeleri doğru almak
100. intended	kastetmek
101. avoided	kaçınılan
102. transmitted	iletilen
103. receivable	alınabilir
104. in both directions	her iki yönde
105. flowed	aktı

After-Reading Activities

Words flow through glass. In both directions. She carries them accurately — and carefully.

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

- | | |
|-----------------|--------------------|
| 1. booth | A. protokol |
| 2. protocol | B. tercüman kabini |
| 3. efficacy | C. yan etkiler |
| 4. side effects | D. etkinlik |
| 5. delegate | E. itibar |
| 6. reputation | F. delege |
| 7. judgement | G. yargı |
| 8. accuracy | H. doğruluk |

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

translate — reported — protocol — cardiac — microphone — judgement

1. Marta's job was to _____ what was said — not to add or remove anything.
2. Dr. Solis said "leave out the _____ incidents" into a live microphone.
3. The _____ says: translate what is said. Marta followed it.

4. Marta heard the sentence clearly because the _____ was still on.
5. She _____ the incident to the conference organiser, not to a journalist.
6. She used her _____ when she decided not to translate the whispered sentence directly.

Answer Key

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Marta translates from English to Spanish. ____
2. Dr. Solis speaks the problematic sentence loudly into the room. ____
3. Helene supports Marta's decision immediately. ____
4. Marta goes to a journalist with the information. ____
5. The drug trial is eventually suspended. ____
6. Marta later gives a talk about professional ethics. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What is an interpreter's protocol, according to Marta?
8. What did Dr. Solis say that Marta did not translate?
9. Why did Marta not translate that sentence into the room?
10. Who does Marta decide to report the incident to?
11. What does the independent review find?
12. How does Helene feel about the situation at the end?
13. What does Marta say at the training day about protocol and judgement?
14. What is Marta's theory about language?
15. What does the final image of the story show?